Bobcats close regular season with dominant win at Pickens

By Caleb James

For The Journal

PICKENS — The Seneca Bobcats left no doubt in their regular-season finale Friday night, rolling past Pickens 48-14 to finish the year 9-1 overall and 5-1 in Region II-4A.

Behind another sharp performance from quarterback Gavin Thoma and a balanced offensive attack, the Bobcats scored touchdowns on their first five possessions and built a 41-0 halftime lead before cruising to their fourth straight win.

“I’m just proud of the effort,” Seneca head coach David Crane said. “I thought we came in and did what we wanted to do. We wanted to get out to a good lead in the first half, and we certainly did that. Then we wanted to have a chance to get guys out of there, and we were able to do that for the whole second half.”

Thoma continued his stellar senior season, throwing four touchdown passes and rushing for another before exiting after the first half. He finished 10-of-11 for 160 yards passing and added a 50-yard touchdown run that stretched Seneca’s early lead. His dominance helped the Bobcats rack up 480 yards of total offense.

“It felt really good,” Thoma said. “We knew coming in that it was a big game, and we needed to win. We made history tonight, the second team in 29 years to win nine games in the regular season. We just came out here, made a statement, and did our thing.”

The Bobcats were explosive from the start. Thoma connected with Jack Webb on a 9-yard touchdown on the opening drive, then broke loose for his 50-yard score minutes later. He followed with an 11-yard touchdown strike to Elias McGee as Seneca built a 21-0 first-quarter lead.

In the second quarter, Thoma found Jerb Hunter for a 4-yard touchdown before handing off to running back Ryan Verner for a 5-yard score. Moments before halftime, Thoma added a 23-yard touchdown pass to Coltyn Hawk, sending Seneca into the locker room up 41-0.

Seneca’s offensive balance was again evident. Verner ran for 108 yards and a touchdown on 11 carries, while junior Jamari Sprout added 63 yards and a short touchdown run. McGee, Webb, and Hawk all caught touchdown passes, while Hunter led all receivers with six receptions for 84 yards.

“I think good balance has helped us,” Crane said. “We’ve been able to throw the ball with success and run the ball with success. A lot of that credit goes to the guys up front. They allow the skill guys to do their thing. Our offensive line has been really solid for us all year.”

Pickens scored twice in the third quarter, once on an 11-yard run by quarterback Nolan Hardin and again on a 35-yard pick-six from Rylie Jonhson, but could not overcome Seneca's dominant first half. The Blue Flame were held to just 117 total yards and six first downs, while the Bobcats piled up 24 first downs and 248 rushing yards.

Now, with a bye week ahead, Seneca turns its focus toward the postseason. The rest will be beneficial after 10 straight games, but Crane emphasized that the next two weeks are also about sharpening fundamentals and preparing for a playoff run.

"We need a break," Crane said. "We need it mentally as much as we do physically. But it's also an important week, a chance for us to work on us a little bit, catch our breath, and hopefully get ready for a good run in November."

Seneca 48, Pickens 14

SHS 21 20 7 0 — 48

PHS 0 0 14 0 — 14

SCORING SUMMARY

First Quarter

SHS — Webb 9 pass from Thoma (Shoemaker kick), 9:10

SHS — Thoma 50 run (Shoemaker kick), 6:26

SHS — McGee 11 pass from Thoma (Shoemaker kick), 0:02

Second Quarter

SHS — Hunter 4 pass from Thoma (kick failed), 6:36

SHS — Verner 5 run (Shoemaker kick), 2:06

SHS — Hawk 23 pass from Thoma (Shoemaker kick), 1:30

Third Quarter

SHS — Sprout 2 run (Shoemaker kick), 9:22

PHS — Hardin 11 run (Smith kick), 2:56

PHS — Johnson 35 Pick-Six (Smith kick), 1:16

Fourth Quarter

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TEAM STATISTICS

SHS PHS

First Downs 24 6

Total Yards 480 117

Rushes-Yards 27-248 32-72

Fumbles-Lost 1-0 0-0

Com-Att-Int 12-17-2 4-4-0

Passing Yards 232 43

Pen-Yards 5-50 3-15

Punts-Avg. 5-42.4 0-0

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INDIVIDUAL STATISTICS

RUSHING — Seneca, Verner 11-108, Sprout 9-63, Thoma 3-67, Kanagy 1-47, McGee 1-11, Bene 2-5, Hunter 1- -6 Pickens, Bolden 11-28, Hardin 14-44, Johnson 6-3, Wilson 1-0.

PASSING — Seneca, Thoma 10-11-0 160, Bene 2-5-2 72; Pickens, Hardin 4-4-43.

RECEIVING — Seneca, Hunter 6-84, Webb 3-32, Hawk 4-55, Kanagy 1-11, Lippert 1-6; Pickens, Wilson 2-14, Bolden 2-16.